When personalization deters delegation to algorithms: Evidence from a preregistered experiment*

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Abstract

Algorithmic decision aids increasingly act on users' behalf, and in many instances users can either retain control or delegate decisions to an algorithm altogether. A common design assumption is that personalizing an algorithm to users' own preferences increases acceptance. Drawing on accounts of the intrinsic value of decision rights, we argue the opposite can hold: a rule that claims to decide as the user would substitutes for the user's own judgment, making the loss of choice authority salient at the moment of delegation. In a preregistered between-subjects experiment (N = 233), participants repeatedly chose whether to decide themselves or to delegate to an algorithm that selected the option with the highest expected value (in one treatment) or implemented participants' previously elicited preferences (in the other). Personalization did not increase delegation at any point of the task; instead, it deterred delegation in two ways. At first contact, participants were significantly less likely to delegate to the preference-based than to the optimization-based algorithm; in subsequent decisions, delegation rates were statistically indistinguishable. Moreover, categorical non-delegation (never delegating) was substantially more prevalent under personalization (15.7% vs. 3.4%). This resistance was not accuracy-based: participants expected the personalized algorithm to match their preferences *better* than the objective rule, yet were no more willing to delegate to it, and never-delegators emphasized retaining responsibility for the choice. Accuracy-based trust and authority-based resistance thus emerge as distinct channels of algorithm acceptance: personalization can improve the former while aggravating the latter.

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